



CARRY THE FLAME!

PLAYER GAME MANUAL

Full rules for players ages 13 and up

Standard 1v1 first - alpha edition

End Phase ownership revision - 1 September 2026

Official alpha documentation - use only approved current card wording and published errata.



Welcome to Carry The Flame!

Carry The Flame! is a head-to-head card game of Catalysts, clever Tricks, and decisive battles. Build a legal deck, protect your Chi, and win through damage, Kills, or Extractions. This manual teaches the full standard game in clear play order.

Read this first: Use current approved card wording. If an old card uses old phase names or unclear timing, do not guess: it needs approved errata before it can be played in current alpha rules.

1. Build a legal deck

Part	Legal size	Important limit
Main Deck	40-60 cards	Maximum 5 Great cards.
Fusion Deck	0-15 cards	Maximum 5 Great Fusion Catalysts.
Substitute Deck	0-15 cards	Used only between games in a Best-of-3 match; resulting decks must remain legal.

A Great card has the exact standalone word Great in its approved name. Similar words, such as Greatness, do not count. Your Main Deck may have 5 Great cards, your Fusion Deck may have 5 Great Fusion Catalysts, and the two decks together may never have more than 10 Great cards.

Fast deck check: Count Main Deck Great cards: 5 or fewer. Count Fusion Deck Great Fusion Catalysts: 5 or fewer. Total the two counts: 10 or fewer.

2. Set up the game

1. Shuffle and present your Main Deck. Put your Fusion and Substitute Decks aside.
2. Each player starts at 10,000 Chi and draws five cards. There is no normal mulligan.
3. Determine the first player. The first player still draws on turn one, but cannot attack during their first Battle Phase.
4. Keep your five Catalyst Zones ready. Each player can have one Field Trick; playing another replaces only your own Field Trick.

3. How you win

Win route	How it happens
Chi KO	Reduce the opponent's Chi to 0 or less.
Kills	Reach seven Kills.
Extractions	Reach seven Extractions.

If more than one winning result happens together, resolve them in this order: Chi KO, then seven Kills, then seven Extractions.

4. Your turn

Phase	What you do
Turn Start	Resolve start-turn effects.
Draw	Draw one card. If your Main Deck is empty, simply skip this draw.
Ignition	Use legal ignition effects.
Action	Spawn, Set, activate cards, and respond in Chains.
Battle	Declare attacks and resolve them. The first player cannot attack here on turn one.
Resolution	Finish effect and trigger resolution.
End	Take one End right or Pass.

5. Spawning Catalysts

You normally get one Normal Spawn or Set each turn; a Set uses the same allowance. Level 1-4 Catalysts need no Tribute, Level 5-6 need one Tribute, and Level 7+ need two Tributes. Tributed Catalysts normally go to the Void.

A Special Spawn happens only when approved wording says the procedure is Special. Do not call a card Special just because it returns, places, replaces, or creates something similar.

The Shotgun Rule: Every time you successfully complete a Special Spawn, your opponent immediately draws one card. The draw happens before on-Spawn effects and before either player gets a response window. Fusion and Libra both count as Special Spawns.

Situation	Does it count?	Does opponent draw?
Successful Special Spawn	Yes: 1 Special Spawn	Yes: 1 immediately.
Successful Fusion	Yes: 1	Yes: 1 immediately.
Successful Libra procedure	Yes: 1 total	Yes: 1 immediately.
Failed or negated Spawn	No	No.

Five is the limit: You may complete at most five Special Spawns in a turn. A sixth Special Spawn cannot happen: do not pay for it, do not place the Catalyst, and do not make the opponent draw.

6. Tricks and Chains

Palm Tricks are generally used from hand at their allowed timing. Concealed Tricks are set and used when their condition is met. Continuous, Equip, Quick, Counter, and Field are subtypes that explain how a Trick stays or reacts.

When a card or effect is activated, players may respond. Put each response on top of the Chain. Resolve the newest link first. Once a Counter Trick is in a Chain, only another Counter Trick can be placed above it. Do as much as possible, but a card cannot be activated if its required instruction cannot happen.

7. Battle

1. Declare an attacking Catalyst and a legal target. You may attack directly only when every opposing Catalyst Zone is empty.
2. Players use any legal effects and responses. Check current Pressure and Counter Pressure.
3. Resolve the result and then any resulting effects.

Battle result	What happens
Pressure vs. Pressure	The lower Pressure Catalyst goes to Void. Its controller takes Chi damage equal to the difference. A tie destroys both and gives one Kill to each player.
Pressure defeats Counter Pressure	Use the approved Counter Pressure result. A defeated non-Great Catalyst is usually Captured to the attacker's Box.
Great loses to Counter Pressure	The Great Catalyst goes to Void, the opponent gets one Kill, and no battle Logic/Chi damage is dealt from that result.
Direct attack	If all five opposing Catalyst Zones are still empty at resolution, deal legal direct damage to Chi.

8. End Phase choices

Choose one: Extract, Rescue, Destroy 1 Trick, or Pass Turn. A paid choice sends one Catalyst you own and control from a Catalyst Zone to the Void. A newly Spawned Catalyst you own may pay. A Catalyst owned by your opponent cannot pay, even while you control it. Taking control does not change ownership. Pass Turn costs nothing.

Choice	Goal
Extract	Move an eligible captured non-Great Catalyst from a Box to RFG and gain one Extraction.
Rescue	Follow the approved Rescue procedure.
Destroy 1 Trick	Follow the approved destruction procedure for one eligible Trick.
Pass Turn	Do nothing at End; pay no End action cost.

9. Important rules to remember

- Destroyed, discarded, and Tributed cards go to Void unless a card says otherwise.
- Cards in RFG stay there until the next game unless the effect that moved them says otherwise.
- Continuous bonuses stack unless a card says they do not.
- A player can control one Field Trick. Each player may have their own Field Trick active at the same time.
- A successful Fusion uses one Special-Spawn count; a successful Libra procedure also uses one, no matter how many eligible Catalysts it places.

10. Worked examples

Shotgun timing

You Special Spawn a Catalyst. It successfully enters play. Your opponent draws one card right away. Only then do that Catalyst's on-Spawn effects and normal response opportunities happen.



Cap timing

You have already completed five Special Spawns this turn. An effect now tries to Special Spawn another Catalyst. That special procedure does not happen, so you do not pay its Special Spawn cost and your opponent does not draw.

Great deck limit

Your Main Deck has five Great cards. You may not add a sixth Great card, even if your Fusion Deck has fewer than five Great Fusion Catalysts.

Direct attack

Your opponent has no Catalysts when you declare a direct attack. They then fill a Catalyst Zone before resolution. Your direct attack no longer meets its empty-zone rule.

Field Tricks

You have one Field Trick and your opponent has one. When you play a new Field Trick, only your old Field Trick is destroyed; your opponent keeps theirs.

End payment you own

You Spawn your own Catalyst this turn. At End, it may pay for Extract, Rescue, or Destroy 1 Trick because you own and control it.

Borrowed Catalyst cannot pay

You control an opponent's Catalyst for a short time. It cannot pay for your End action because your opponent still owns it. It returns when the control effect says it should.

11. Team and event play

In 2v2, each player has their own hand and Normal Spawn. The team shares completed Special Spawns, card-name limits, per-card usage, Chi, field resources, Kills, and Extractions unless the format says otherwise. The team can complete only five Special Spawns per turn. Boss and Free For All events use their published format sheet; do not assume a default Free For All procedure.

Quick glossary

Term	Meaning
Catalyst	A character, unit, or game piece that can occupy a Catalyst Zone.
Chi	Your life total. Start at 10,000.
Pressure / Counter Pressure	The battle values used by attacking and defending Catalysts.
Void	The normal destination for destroyed, discarded, and Tributed cards.
Box	Where captured non-Great Catalysts are held.
RFG	Removed From Game. Cards normally remain there until the next game.
Great	A card whose approved name contains the exact standalone word Great.